

House Rules

Encumbrance: In this campaign, we will deal with encumbrance only situationally. That means I will bring it up only when it seems unavoidable. "Do you really want to climb that sheer cliff carrying a bag of anvils?"

Persistent Wounds: Each time a character comes back from dying (either by succeeding at three Death Saving Throws or by means of healing), they gain a level of "Wounded." The ONLY impact of being Wounded is that the next time that character is dropped unconscious in combat, he or she will automatically start with a number of Death Saving Throw fails equal to his or her Wounded Level. After coming back once, they have Wounded 1 and start with one failure the next time they drop. If they have Wounded 2, they start with two failures. And if they have Wounded 3, the next time they are dropped in this combat will be their last. Basically, the fourth time a character drops in there same combat, they die automatically. Characters can remove a level of Wounded during each short rest, and two levels of Wounded during each long rest.

Epic Damage to the Dying: Under current 5e rules, if a character gets hit with a melee attack while dying, they incur a Death Save Fail. Same here, but if the damage is more than 25 points, the character incurs two Death Save Fails. If the damage is more than 50 points, they incur three Death Save Fails and the PC is DEAD.

Help for the Dying: When a player has gone down, any other player can take the Help action to assist their fallen comrade, giving her advantage on the next Death Saving Throw. If the player assisting is proficient in the Medicine skill, the Help action automatically succeeds. If not, she can use a skill other than Medicine, but if she does then she has to describe what she is doing and roll against a DC of 10. For example, she might roll a strength check to apply pressure to the wound or a perception check to detect the source of all that blood, or a nature check to know that packing some nearby flora into the wound will help, or a dexterity check to carefully remove fragments from the wound, etc. The goal is to be more dramatic and tell a story with more details!

Heroic Recovery: If your character is dying, they take their Death Saving Throw at the beginning of their turn and, if they make their third success, they stabilize at 1 HP and may immediately take their full action.

Advantage Stacks: Under current 5e rules, it is impossible to benefit from more than one condition that provides advantage, or to be harmed by more than one condition that provides disadvantage. In my game, each level of advantage and disadvantage cancel each other out one for one, and any additional advantage left over beyond the first provides a +1 bonus and each level of additional disadvantage provides a -1 penalty.

For example, let's say Jill and Bob both use the Help action to assist Ben in moving a fallen tree out of the road, giving him two levels of advantage. Ben has a special background that gives him advantage on such tests of strength (so, that's three levels of advantage!), but the DM rules that tree is especially heavy due to it being a special kind of stonework tree and applies one level of disadvantage. The first level of advantage and disadvantage cancel each other out, leaving two levels of advantage. Hence, Ben makes his Athletics check with advantage and with a +1 bonus.

Dramatic Combat Advantage: Instead of using the very uninspired and mechanically boring flanking rules, we will use the more interesting and creativity-enhancing rule known as "Dramatic Combat Advantage." When in combat (or preparing for combat), your character can

put himself in a position to gain advantage on his next attack by using some feature of the physical terrain described by the DM or shown on the map. The DM will set a skill check needed to gain the advantage. If your PC succeeds the skill check, he gains advantage. If he fails the skill check, he does not. If he fails the skill check by 5 or more, he takes disadvantage on his next attack or suffers some other condition that is consistent with what he attempted.

First example. Fyn notices that the evil druid is standing near a puddle. Fyn says he will call to the druid hoping to lure him to step in the puddle and readies an action of casting a spell that does lightning damage and requires a spell attack roll. The DM decides Fyn must succeed at a DC 13 Persuasion check. If he succeeds, the druid steps in the puddle and Fyn will make his spell attack roll with advantage, because the spell will work whether it hits the druid or the puddle he is standing in. If Fyn fails the check, the druid doesn't fall for it and Fyn's attack happens as normal. If Fyn fails the check by more than 5, the druid sees Fyn staring at the puddle and figures out what he was trying to do, such that Fyn's next attack against the druid (no matter what it is) happens at a disadvantage.

Second example. Ezrill decides to use his movement to approach an enemy mage across the ballroom, but rather than run through all those dancers (difficult terrain!), he decides to jump onto the chandelier and swing towards the enemy mage like a swashbuckler. The DM makes him roll an acrobatics check with a DC of 10. If Ezrill makes the check, he swings over the crowd and gains advantage on his attack. If he fails the check, he has still used the chandelier to swing toward where the mage is, but he only swung as far as he would have been able to move on foot and does not gain advantage on the attack. If he fails the check by 5 or more, he falls from the chandelier and lands prone in the middle of the crowd of dancers.

Third example. Nivek is hiding behind a stack of crates and wants to push the crates over onto the assassin who is hiding on the other side of the crates and then attack the assassin while she is pinned down by crates. The DM decides an athletics check is necessary, DC 10. If Nivek makes the check, he successfully pushes the crates onto the assassin and gains advantage on his attack against her. If he fails, perhaps he couldn't get the crates to budge, but the assassin heard the grunt and knows someone is there. If he fails by 5 or more, perhaps the crates fall on him and he must use half his movement to get out from under them and regain his feet, and will have disadvantage on his attack because the assassin is fully warned and can see him. The point of the Dramatic Combat Advantage rule is to give you an incentive to take risks in combat. But they will be RISKS, because there is a potential downside. Side Note: If your PC has a class feature or a feat that allows you to gain advantage in combat by studying your opponent or using a skill or some other special method that is not available to those who lack that class or feat, we will modify it so that your special feature is not nerfed. Most likely, the feat will give you advantage on the skill check needed to establish dramatic advantage.